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**FEATURES 300
MOST USEFUL
SPANISH VERBS**

Barbara Bregstein

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***Master High-Frequency Grammar
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Barbara Bregstein

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Preface

Easy Spanish Step-by-Step will help you learn Spanish—talking, reading, and writing—as quickly and as thoroughly as possible. Written for beginner and advanced-beginner learners, it teaches grammar and conversation in the most logical order to enable you to develop your language skills naturally.

To take full advantage of the unique grammatical progression of the book, you should study each chapter, or step, one after another. Do not skip around. Each step you take will lead you to the next. Each chapter contains clear grammar explanations; be sure to understand every concept before moving on to the next. Notice that there are few exceptions to rules, so once you have learned a concept, it is yours.

Try to learn the vocabulary and verbs provided; they have been carefully selected on the basis of usefulness and frequency. The vocabulary lists will help enhance your communication, while complete verb conjugations are given so that you can practice pronunciation as you learn verbs. Over 300 of the most common verbs in Spanish are presented.

Varied written and oral exercises are included to check your understanding and progress. (The book has a complete answer key in the back.) It is also a good idea to write your own questions and sentences and practice them aloud. Sometimes, your own creations are more interesting and aid in learning.

Original readings are included in every chapter; they become progressively more challenging in form and content throughout the book. Use these reading comprehension sections to learn new vocabulary and to practice reading aloud.

Easy Spanish Step-by-Step is divided into three parts. The first gives you all the fundamentals of the language in the present tense. You will notice that the word order of English and Spanish in this part is essentially the same. This makes learning in the early stages very quick. The second part

explains indirect objects, direct objects, direct object pronouns, reflexive verbs, and the present subjunctive. The third part presents the two most used tenses in the past, the preterit and the imperfect.

A student once asked me if Spanish is truly easy. It is, in comparison to any of the other languages of the world. To start with, the pronunciation is easy. Spanish is a phonetically perfect language, which means that once you learn to pronounce each vowel and consonant, you will be able to pronounce all words correctly. Before you begin, practice all the sounds outlined in the Guide to Pronunciation in the following pages. If possible, try to practice with a native speaker. Then, remember to read and answer questions aloud as much as you can to develop your pronunciation.

This book is written with a logical approach that makes it accessible, whether you are a self-study learner or a student in an organized teaching program. With *Easy Spanish Step-by-Step*, you will see that everything falls quickly into place. In a few weeks, you will be able to read and write Spanish quite easily. And once you learn the Spanish in this book, you will be able to get along in any Spanish-speaking country. The grammar is standard in all parts of the Spanish-speaking world, and although accents change from place to place, you will get accustomed to the sounds very quickly. Have fun and enjoy using Spanish everywhere you need it.

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Guide to Pronunciation

Spanish spelling is an exact reflection of the pronunciation of the language. The pronunciation of each letter is subject to precise and consistent rules, and words are pronounced by adding together the sounds of each individual letter.

Vowels

The sounds of the vowels are clear and short. Pronounce the examples.

Letter	Pronounced like	Examples
a	the <i>a</i> in <i>father</i>	la casa, la tapa, Panamá, Canadá
e	two sounds: the <i>e</i> in <i>café</i> when final the <i>e</i> in <i>set</i> elsewhere	elefante, come, vive, verde, que pero, es, hotel
i	the <i>i</i> in <i>machine</i>	sí, cine, comida
o	two sounds: the <i>o</i> in <i>hope</i> the <i>o</i> in <i>for</i> if followed by r	oso, otro, hospital doctor, profesor
u	the <i>u</i> in <i>rule</i> written as ü when pronounced in güe and güi silent in gue and gui elsewhere	uno, tú, puro agüero, güira
y	Spanish i	guerra, guitarra y, soy, hay

Consonants

b/v	the <i>b</i> in <i>boat</i> when they occur at the beginning of a breath group, or following l , m , or n softer elsewhere, produced through slightly opened lips	baño, burro, embargo, alba, el vino, el voto, invierno, vamos Cuba, la boca, Havana, la vaca
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In Spanish, the *b* and *v* have the same sound. The sound of English *v* does not exist in Spanish.

c	the <i>c</i> in <i>cat</i> before a , o , u , or before a consonant	camisa, color, concreto
	the <i>s</i> in <i>sail</i> before e or i	centavo, cita, cinco
ch	the <i>ch</i> in <i>chum</i>	chocolate, chorizo

Letter	Pronounced like	Examples
d	two sounds: the <i>d</i> in <i>dog</i> when it occurs at the beginning of a breath group, or following l or n the <i>th</i> in <i>other</i> elsewhere	donde, falda, conde boda, poder, verdad, nada, cada, estudio
f	English <i>f</i>	futuro, fila, oficina
g	the <i>g</i> in <i>game</i> before a , o , u , or before a consonant	gato, gusto, grande
	the <i>h</i> in <i>hat</i> before e or i	genio, generoso, gitano
h	silent	hombre, hasta, hablar
j	English <i>h</i> (It can also be given a slightly guttural sound.)	Juan, ojo, mujer
k	English <i>k</i>	kayak, kilómetro, kiwi
l	English <i>l</i> , but with the tip of the tongue touching the roof of the mouth	el, hotel, mil, palo
ll	the <i>y</i> in <i>beyond</i> , or in some countries, the <i>s</i> in <i>pleasure</i>	caballo, bello, llave
m	English <i>m</i>	menos, cama, marrón
n	English <i>n</i>	nota, nación, nariz
ñ	the <i>ny</i> in <i>canyon</i> or the <i>ni</i> in <i>onion</i>	mañana, España, señor
p	English <i>p</i> , but not explosive (without the puff of air in the English sound)	papel, persona, pobre
q	the <i>k</i> in <i>key</i> (found only in the combinations que and qui)	Quito, queso, equipo
r	the <i>dd</i> in <i>ladder</i> (a single tongue flap) The r at the beginning of a word or after l , n , or s is trilled like rr .	caro, barato, para, hablar rosa, el río, Enrique, las rosas
rr	a trill or tongue roll (There is no equivalent sound in English.)	perro, horrible, carro

Letter	Pronounced like	Examples
s	English <i>s</i>	sopa, sala, blusa
t	English <i>t</i> , but not explosive (with the tip of the tongue against the back of the upper front teeth)	torta, talento, tesoro
v	Spanish b (There is no <i>v</i> sound in Spanish.)	
w	The letter w exists in Spanish only in words of foreign origin and is not considered part of the Spanish alphabet.	
x	English <i>x</i>	experto, examen
y	Spanish ll (the <i>y</i> in <i>beyond</i> or, in some countries, the <i>s</i> in <i>pleasure</i>)	papaya, papagayo, ayer
z	the <i>s</i> in <i>sail</i>	azul, brazo, luz

Stress, Written Accentuation, and Spelling

Natural Stress

Words that end in a vowel (**a**, **e**, **i**, **o**, **u**) or the consonants **n** or **s** have their natural stress on the next to last syllable.

cucar <u>a</u> cha	volum <u>e</u> n
mañ <u>a</u> na	exam <u>e</u> n
trist <u>e</u>	tomat <u>e</u> s
habl <u>o</u>	

Words that end in any consonant other than **n** or **s** have their natural stress on the final syllable.

salud	mujer
amistad	cantar
papel	doctor
vegetal	nariz
azul	

Written Accents

When a word does not follow one of these two rules, it will have a written accent on the syllable that is stressed.

tel <u>é</u> fono	canc <u>í</u> ón
lám <u>p</u> ara	lecc <u>í</u> ón
m <u>ú</u> sica	dif <u>í</u> cil
café	fá <u>c</u> il

If a one-syllable word has a written accent, it means that there is another word in the language that has the same spelling, but another meaning.

el	<i>the</i>	él	<i>he</i>
si	<i>if</i>	sí	<i>yes</i>
tu	<i>your</i>	tú	<i>you</i>
se	<i>oneself</i>	sé	<i>I know</i>

If a two-syllable word has a written accent that does not affect the pronunciation, it means that there is another word that has the same spelling, but a different meaning.

este	<i>this</i>	éste	<i>this one</i>
ese	<i>that</i>	ése	<i>that one</i>

Interrogative words have an accent mark that does not affect pronunciation.

¿qué?	<i>what?</i>	¿cómo?	<i>how?</i>
¿quién?	<i>who?</i>	¿por qué?	<i>why?</i>
¿dónde?	<i>where?</i>	¿cuál?	<i>which?</i>

Spelling Changes

- **z to c**

Nouns and adjectives that end in **z** change to **c** to form the plural.

el lápiz	los lápices
la nariz	las narices
feliz	felices

Z followed by **a** or **o** changes to **c** before an **e** or **i**. The sound of **z** and **c** are the same.

comienza	comience
empiezo	empiece

- **Other spelling changes**

All other spelling changes occur in order to maintain a required sound.

Tocar, for example, has a hard *c* sound that must be preserved in other forms of the verb. If you see **toque**, with **qu** replacing the **c**, it is to maintain the *k* sound.

Llegar, for example, has a hard *g* sound, which must be preserved. If you see **llegue**, with **gu** replacing the **g**, it is to maintain the hard *g* sound.

Castilian Spanish

There are only a few differences in pronunciation between the Spanish spoken in Latin America and that spoken in Spain.

- Both the **c** that precedes **e** or **i** and the **z** have the *th* sound heard in English *thought* and *thing*.
- When **j** or **g** precedes **e** or **i**, it has a slightly more guttural sound.



Tips for Pronunciation

- While practicing, remember to keep the vowel sounds short and clear.
- Always use the Spanish **r** sound. Resist the use of the English *r*.
- Implore the sounds of **p** and **t**. Make sure there is no puff of air.
- Always pronounce **z** like the letter **s**.
- Give the syllables an almost equal emphasis, a sort of staccato sound. Pronounce every syllable clearly and precisely in order to develop an even speech pattern.

The Alphabet

El alfabeto o abecedario

Letter(s)	Name	Letter(s)	Name
A	a	N	ene
B	be larga / be grande	Ñ	eñe
C	ce	O	o
CH	che	P	pe
D	de	Q	cu
E	e	R	ere
F	efe	RR	erre
G	ge	S	ese
H (always silent)	hache	T	te
I	i	U	u
J	jota	V	ve corta
K	ka	W	doble ve / doble u
L	ele	X	equis
LL	elle	Y	i griega / ye
M	eme	Z	zeta

Greetings and Salutations

Hola.	<i>Hello.</i>
Buenos días.	<i>Good morning.</i>
Buenas tardes.	<i>Good afternoon.</i>
Buenas noches.	<i>Good evening.</i>
Me llamo Susana.	<i>My name is Susan.</i>
¿Cómo se llama usted?	<i>What's your name?</i>
Me llamo David.	<i>My name is David.</i>
Mucho gusto.	<i>Pleased to meet you.</i>
¿Cómo está usted?	<i>How are you?</i>
Bien, gracias, ¿y usted?	<i>Fine, thanks. And you?</i>
Regular. Más o menos.	<i>So-so. More or less.</i>
Hasta luego.	<i>So long.</i>
Hasta mañana.	<i>Until tomorrow.</i>
Hasta pronto.	<i>See you soon.</i>
Adiós.	<i>Good-bye.</i>